

ANGEL ACTION · TRAUMA

Suspected Spinal Injury

Suspect a spinal injury in any fall from height, road crash, diving incident, or unresponsive trauma patient. Do not move the person unless they are in danger; keep the head and neck steady and call 000.

Suspect a spinal injury when

- A fall from height
- Diving or surfing accident
- Road traffic crash
- Crush or significant blunt trauma
- Any unconscious trauma patient

Signs (in a conscious patient)

- Pain in the neck or back
- Numbness, tingling or loss of sensation
- Inability to move arms or legs
- Loss of bladder or bowel control

What to do

1. **Call 000.**
2. Tell the person **not to move** and reassure them.
3. Support the head with your hands either side, keeping the head in line with the body. Do not pull or twist.
4. If they must be moved (e.g. danger, vomiting, or to do CPR), use a **log-roll** with multiple helpers, keeping the head, neck and back aligned.
5. If unconscious but breathing, carefully place in a modified **recovery position** supporting the head and neck.
6. If not breathing normally, airway always comes first — start **CPR**.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.